

University Centre Abdelhafid Boussouf E-learning Centre



English – Level 2

– Lesson 07 –

Key Components of a Paragraph

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Students Concerned- Semester 3

Institute	Department	Year	Speciality
Letters and Languages	• Foreign Languages	Licentiate 2	French
Science and Technology	• Mathematics and Computer Science • Technical Science	Licentiate 2	•MI •ST
Economic Science	• Economic Science • Commercial Science • Management Science	Licentiate 2	All specialties

Objectives of the Lesson

- To provide a range of defining aspects that most basic English paragraph types share.
- To enable students to successfully engage in the construction of proper paragraphs.

1. What is a Paragraph?

A paragraph is a combination of sentences; it expresses a **topic**, a **main idea**, a **theme** or a **set of specific thoughts** on a particular subject. The **topic** of a paragraph is the **most general idea**; all of the sentences are about **the topic**. Furthermore, in order for a paragraph to be coherent and make total sense, all sentences must be related to the context of the paragraph. A paragraph should be double-spaced and it must begin with **an indentation**. In case there is only **one single paragraph** (on its own), it usually has a **title**. Basically, the length of a paragraph does not depend on the number of sentences, but rather on its ideas.

2. Key Components of a Paragraph

When it comes to the body of a regular paragraph and its organization, it mainly consists of **three major elements** arranged as follows: **a topic sentence**, **supporting sentences**, and **a concluding sentence**.

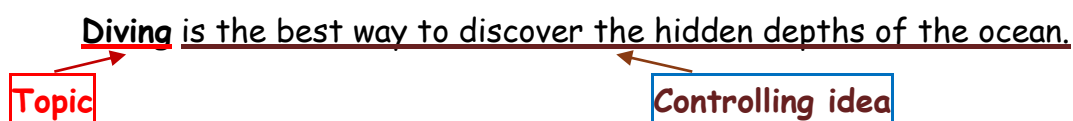
1. Topic Sentence

The **topic sentence** is the initial sentence in a paragraph; it is usually the first or second sentence in a regular paragraph. The **topic sentence** introduces the central idea and explains briefly what the paragraph will

provide about **the topic**; this explanation is called the controlling idea. The **controlling idea** must provide a piece of information about **the topic** that can then be supported and developed in **the supporting sentences**. The **controlling idea** must be short and specific; otherwise, **the topic sentence** will be unclear.

Example of a Topic Sentence:

Diving is the best way to discover the hidden depths of the ocean.

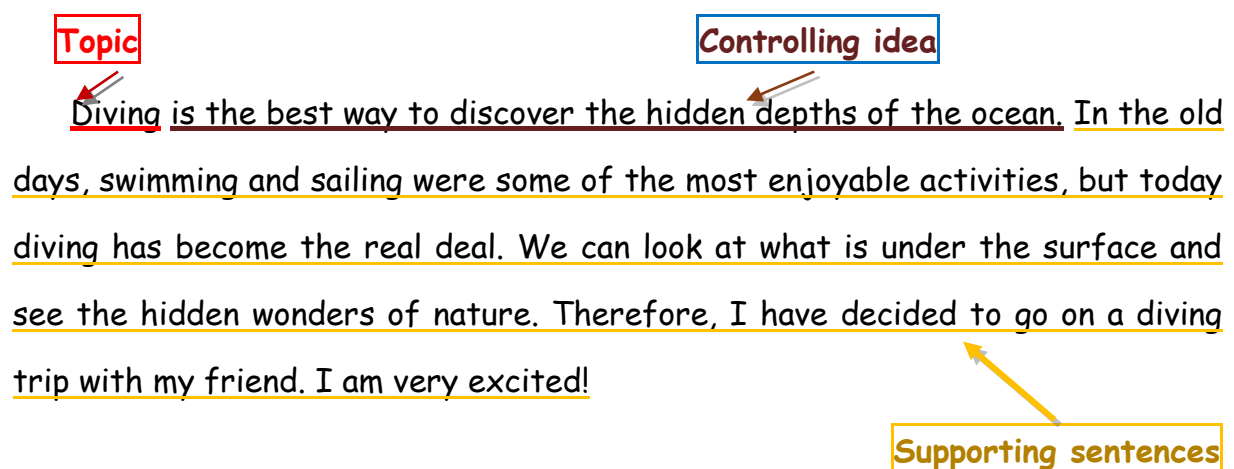


2. Supporting Sentences

Supporting sentences add information about **the topic sentence** (both topic and controlling idea). The main purpose of **supporting sentences** is to explain and support **the topic sentence**; they can include: definitions, explanations and examples. In other terms, every **supporting sentence** in **the paragraph** must help the development of **the topic sentence**

Example of supporting Sentences:

Diving is the best way to discover the hidden depths of the ocean. In the old days, swimming and sailing were some of the most enjoyable activities, but today diving has become the real deal. We can look at what is under the surface and see the hidden wonders of nature. Therefore, I have decided to go on a diving trip with my friend. I am very excited!



3. Concluding Sentence

The *concluding sentence* often repeats the idea of the *topic sentence* in an alternative way. The *concluding sentence* of a *paragraph* usually reminds the reader of the *topic* and *controlling idea* of the *paragraph*. In other words, the *concluding sentence* re-states the main idea in a different form.

Example of a Concluding Sentence:

The diagram illustrates the structure of a paragraph. A box labeled 'Indentation' has an arrow pointing to the start of the paragraph text. A box labeled 'Title' has an arrow pointing to the word 'Diving'. A box labeled 'Concluding sentence' has an arrow pointing to the final sentence of the paragraph.

Indentation **Title** → Diving

Diving is the best way to discover the hidden depths of the ocean. In the old days, swimming and sailing were some of the most enjoyable activities, but today diving has become the real deal, through which we can look at what is under the surface and see the hidden wonders of nature. Therefore, I have decided to go on a diving trip with my friend. I am very excited! I like to discover nature, so I think that diving deep into the ocean is my new passion.

Concluding sentence

Let's Practice!

*Identify the **topic** and the **controlling idea** in each of the following topic sentence

1. My teacher is very kind to her students.
2. Every college student should take online courses.
3. Dogs are a good companion for humans.
4. Video games are addictive.

* Are the following sentences **topic sentences** or **supporting sentences**?

1. Bees have a long straw called a proboscis.
2. Bees are interesting insects.
3. Bees produce honey.
4. Bees have a major role in pollination.

References

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- Savage, Alice and Masoud Shafiei - Effective Academic Writing 1 Student Book: The Paragraph. New York, Oxford University Press, 2007.